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Catching protection assembly and method

Abstract

A catching protection assembly comprising a catching protection cover configured to be donned by a catcher to protect to protect at least the catcher's knees, shins, and toes during catching; a groin area protector operatively associated with the container to protect at least the catcher's groin area during catching; a combination container and seat configured to contain and transport at least the catching protection cover and the groin area protector in a transport configuration and support a catcher in a seat configuration, wherein, in the transport configuration, the container contains and transports at least the catching protection cover and the groin area protector, and in a seat configuration, the container supports a catcher seated thereon.

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Background/Summary

FIELD OF THE INVENTION

(1) The present invention relates protectors for catching pitched baseballs.

BACKGROUND OF THE INVENTION

(2) In baseball/softball, it is common for a parent or coach to perform catching for practicing pitchers. The parent/coach would normally put on a catcher's normal protective gear, crouch into a catcher's position, and catch pitches from the practicing pitcher. However, putting on catcher's protective gear is time-consuming and often not necessary.

SUMMARY OF THE INVENTION

(3) Accordingly, an aspect of the disclosure that eliminates the time-consuming need to put on a catcher's normal protective gear involves a catching protection assembly and method for parents/coaches that do catching for practicing pitchers. The catching protection assembly includes a catching protection kilt with pads to protect the toes, knees, and groin areas of the catcher. In an implementation of this aspect of the disclosure, a container such as a bucket is not only used to store and transport the catching protection, but also serves as a seat for the catcher to rest on while catching. A groin area protector is operatively associated with a top edge of the container to protect the groin area of the catcher while catching.

(4) An additional aspect of the disclosure involves a catching protection assembly comprising a catching protection cover configured to be donned by a catcher to protect to protect at least the catcher's knees, shins, and toes during catching; a groin area protector operatively associated with the container to protect at least the catcher's groin area during catching; a combination container and seat configured to contain and transport at least the catching protection cover and the groin area protector in a transport configuration and support a catcher in a seat configuration, wherein, in the transport configuration, the container contains and transports at least the catching protection cover and the groin area protector, and in a seat configuration, the container supports a catcher seated thereon.

(5) One or more implementations of the aspect of the disclosure described immediately above includes one or more of the following: the catching protection cover includes one or more of laterally spaced pairs of knee protectors, shin protectors, and toe protectors with a central protection section spanning a central lateral distance between the one or more of laterally spaced pairs of knee protectors, shin protectors, and toe protectors; the container includes a front and a top edge, and the groin area protector is operatively associated with the top edge and the front of the container to secure the groin area protector to the front of the container to protect the groin area of the catcher while catching; the groin area protector includes a tongue member and a pair of parallel retainer members spaced from the tongue member to form a container front receiver configured to slide over and receive the front of the container to secure the groin area protector to the container; the groin area protector includes container front receiver configured to slide over and receive the front of the container to secure the groin area protector to the container, and a groin protection member that extends forward and upward from the container front receiver and the front of the container to protect the groin area of the catcher while catching; the groin protection member includes a top and tapers in width progressing from a greater width at the container front receiver to a lesser width at the top of the groin protection member; and/or the container includes a reversible and combination lid and seat with one side having a rigid top surface and an opposite side having a cushion member.

(6) A further aspect of the disclosure involve a method of using a catching protection assembly comprising a catching protection cover configured to be donned by a catcher to protect to protect at least the catcher's knees, shins, and toes during catching; a groin area protector operatively associated with the container to protect at least the catcher's groin area during catching; a combination container and seat configured to contain and transport at least the catching protection cover and the groin area protector in a transport configuration and support a catcher in a seat configuration, wherein, in the transport configuration, the container contains and transports at least the catching protection cover and the groin area protector, and in a seat configuration, the container supports a catcher seated thereon, the method comprising transporting at least the catching protection cover and the groin area protector in the container with the container in the transport configuration; receiving the catcher seated on the container with the container in the seat configuration; donning the catching protection cover so that the catcher's knees, shins, and toes are covered and protected during catching; operatively associating the groin area protector to container to protect at least the catcher's groin area during catching.

(7) One or more implementations of the aspect of the disclosure described immediately above includes one or more of the following: the catching protection cover includes one or more of laterally spaced pairs of knee protectors, shin protectors, and toe protectors with a central protection section spanning a central lateral distance between the one or more of laterally spaced pairs of knee protectors, shin protectors, and toe protectors, and donning the catching protection cover includes donning the catching protection cover so that the central protection section spans the central lateral distance, and the catcher's knees, shins, and toes are covered and protected during catching; the container includes a front and a top edge, and the groin area protector is operatively associated with the top edge and the front of the container to secure the groin area protector to the front of the container to protect the groin area of the catcher while catching, and operatively associating the groin area protector includes operatively associating the groin area protector with the top edge and the front of the container to protect at least the catcher's groin area during catching; the groin area protector includes a container front receiver configured to slide over and receive the front of the container to secure the groin area protector to the container, and a groin protection member that extends forward and upward from the container front receiver and the front of the container to protect the groin area of the catcher while catching, and operatively associating the groin area protector includes receiving the container front receiver over the front of the container to secure the groin area protector to the container; and/or the container includes a reversible and combination lid and seat with one side having a rigid top surface and an opposite side having a cushion member, and transporting with the container includes transporting with the rigid top surface of the reversible and combination lid and seat face up, and receiving on the container includes receiving the catcher seated on the container with the cushion member face up.

Description

BRIEF DESCRIPTION OF DRAWINGS

- (1) The accompanying drawings, which are incorporated in and form a part of this specification illustrate embodiments of the invention and together with the description, serve to explain the principles of the invention.
- (2) FIG. 1 is a perspective view of an embodiment of a catching protection assembly.
- (3) FIG. 2 is a perspective view of the catching protection assembly of FIG. 1 shown in use.
- (4) FIG. 3 is a perspective view of a groin area protector of the catching protection assembly of FIG. 1 shown applied to an edge of a container of the catching protection assembly.
- (5) FIG. 4 is a perspective view of the groin area protector shown applied to the edge of a container of the catching protection assembly similar to FIG. 3 and shows a combination lid and seat of the of the catching protection assembly shown applied to a top of the container.

DESCRIPTION OF EMBODIMENT OF THE INVENTION

- (6) With reference to FIGS. 1-4, an embodiment of a catching protection assembly **100** and method of using the same for parents/coaches that do catching for practicing pitchers will be described. The catching protection assembly ("assembly") **100** eliminates the time-consuming need to put on a catcher's normal protective gear.
- (7) In one or more embodiments, the catching protection assembly **100** includes one or more of a catching protection cover or kilt **110**, a groin area protector **120**, and a container (e.g., bucket) **130**.
- (8) The catching protection cover **110** includes a protective shield **140** with one or more of spaced pairs of knee protectors (e.g., pads) **150**, shin protectors (e.g., pads) **160**, and toe protectors **170**. A central protective section **175** spans a central lateral distance between the laterally disposed/spaced knee protectors **150**, shin protectors **160**, and toe protectors **170**. One or more straps **180** are attached along opposite sides **190** of the protective shield **140** and include fastener(s) (e.g., hook and loop fasteners) to secure the catching protection cover **110** around/behind legs **200** of a catcher

210.

(9) With reference to FIGS. 3 and 4, the groin area protector **120** is operatively associated with a top edge **220** of the container **130** to secure the groin area protector **120** to a front **230** of the container **130** to protect the groin area of the catcher **210** while catching. The groin area protector **120** includes a tongue member **240** spaced from a pair of parallel retainer members **245** that form a container front receiver **250** that slides over and receives the front **230** of the container **130** to secure the groin area protector **120** to the container **130**. A groin protection member **260** extends forward and upward from the container front receiver **250** and the front **230** of the container **130** to protect the groin area of the catcher **210** while catching. The groin protection member **260** tapers in width **W** progressing from a greater width at the container front receiver **250** to a lesser width at a top **270** of the groin protection member **260**.

(10) The container **130** includes a cylindrical container body **280**, a carrying handle **290** pivotally coupled to the cylindrical container body **280**, and a reversible and combination lid and seat **300** with a rigid top surface **310** on one side **320** and a disc-shaped cushion member **330** on an opposite side **340**.

(11) A method of using the catching protection assembly **100** by parents/coaches during catching for practicing pitchers will be described. The method comprises transporting at least the catching protection cover **110** and the groin area protector **120** in the container **130** with the container **130** in a transport configuration where the reversible and combination lid and seat **300** is on the top **270** of the container with the rigid top surface **310** of the side **320** face up. The container **130** receives the catcher seated on the container **130** with the container **130** in the seat configuration where the reversible and combination lid and seat **300** is on the top **270** of the container with the disc-shaped cushion member **330** of the opposite side **340** face up. The catching protection cover **110** is donned so that the catcher's knees, shins, and toes are covered and protected during catching. The groin area protector **120** is operatively associated with/to container **130** to protect at least the catcher's groin area during catching.

(12) In one or more implementations of the above method of using the catching protection assembly **100**, the catching protection cover **110** includes one or more of the laterally spaced pairs of knee protectors **150**, shin protectors **160**, and toe protectors **170** with the central protection section **175** spanning the central lateral distance between the one or more of the laterally spaced pairs of knee protectors **150**, shin protectors **160**, and toe protectors **170**, and donning the catching protection cover **110** includes donning the catching protection cover **110** so that the central protection section **175** spans the central lateral distance, and the catcher's knees, shins, and toes are covered and protected during catching; the groin area protector **120** is operatively associated with the top edge **220** and the front **230** of the container **130** to secure the groin area protector **120** to the front of the container **130** to protect the groin area of the catcher while catching, and operatively associating the groin area protector **120** includes operatively associating the groin area protector **120** with the top edge **220** and the front **230** of the container **130** to protect at least the catcher's groin area during catching; operatively associating the groin area protector **120** includes receiving the container front receiver **250** over the front **230** of the container **130** to secure the groin area protector **120** to the container **130**; and/or the transporting with the container **130** includes transporting with the rigid top surface **130** of the reversible and combination lid and seat **300** face up, and receiving on the container **130** includes receiving the catcher seated on the container **130** with the cushion member **330** face up.

(13) Advantages of the catching protection assembly **100** include eliminating the time-consuming need to put on a catcher's normal protective gear when catching for practicing pitchers. The catching protection cover **110** protects the toes, knees, and groin areas of the catcher and the central protective section **175** protects these areas of the catcher and the back of the catcher's legs from balls rebounding off the front **230** of the container **130**. The container **130** not only serves to store and transport at least the catching protective gear (and other gear (e.g., catcher's mit, balls), but also

serves as a seat for the catcher to rest on while catching. The groin area protector **120** quickly and easily attaches to and is removed from the front **230** of the container **130** to protect the groin area of the catcher while catching.

(14) The figures may depict exemplary configurations for the invention, which is done to aid in understanding the features and functionality that can be included in the invention. The invention is not restricted to the illustrated architectures or configurations, but can be implemented using a variety of alternative architectures and configurations. Additionally, although the invention is described above in terms of various exemplary embodiments and implementations, it should be understood that the various features and functionality described in one or more of the individual embodiments with which they are described, but instead can be applied, alone or in some combination, to one or more of the other embodiments of the invention, whether or not such embodiments are described and whether or not such features are presented as being a part of a described embodiment. Thus the breadth and scope of the present invention, especially in the following claims, should not be limited by any of the above-described exemplary embodiments.

(15) Terms and phrases used in this document, and variations thereof, unless otherwise expressly stated, should be construed as open ended as opposed to limiting. As examples of the foregoing: the term “including” should be read as mean “including, without limitation” or the like; the term “example” is used to provide exemplary instances of the item in discussion, not an exhaustive or limiting list thereof; and adjectives such as “conventional,” “traditional,” “standard,” “known” and terms of similar meaning should not be construed as limiting the item described to a given time period or to an item available as of a given time, but instead should be read to encompass conventional, traditional, normal, or standard technologies that may be available or known now or at any time in the future. Likewise, a group of items linked with the conjunction “and” should not be read as requiring that each and every one of those items be present in the grouping, but rather should be read as “and/or” unless expressly stated otherwise. Similarly, a group of items linked with the conjunction “or” should not be read as requiring mutual exclusivity among that group, but rather should also be read as “and/or” unless expressly stated otherwise. Furthermore, although item, elements or components of the disclosure may be described or claimed in the singular, the plural is contemplated to be within the scope thereof unless limitation to the singular is explicitly stated. The presence of broadening words and phrases such as “one or more,” “at least,” “but not limited to” or other like phrases in some instances shall not be read to mean that the narrower case is intended or required in instances where such broadening phrases may be absent.

Claims

1. A method of using a catching protection assembly, the catching protection assembly comprising a catching protection cover configured to be donned by a catcher configured to protect at least a catcher's knees, shins, and toes during catching; a groin area protector operatively associated with a container configured to protect at least a catcher's groin area during catching; the combination container and seat configured to contain and transport at least the catching protection cover and the groin area protector in a transport configuration and support the catcher in a seat configuration, wherein in the transport configuration, the container contains and transports at least the catching protection cover and the groin area protector, in the seat configuration, the container configured to support the catcher seated thereon, the method comprising: transporting at least the catching protection cover and the groin area protector in the container with the container in the transport configuration; receiving the catcher seated on the container with the container in the seat configuration; donning the catching protection cover so that the catcher's knees, shins, and toes are covered and protected during catching; operatively associating the groin area protector to the container configured to protect at least the catcher's groin area during catching.
2. A method of using the catching protection assembly of claim 1, wherein the catching protection

cover includes one or more of laterally spaced pairs of knee protectors, shin protectors, and toe protectors with a central protection section spanning a central lateral distance between the one or more of laterally spaced pairs of knee protectors, shin protectors, and toe protectors, and donning the catching protection cover includes donning the catching protection cover so that the central protection section spans the central lateral distance, and the catcher's knees, shins, and toes are configured to be covered and protected during catching.

3. A method of using the catching protection assembly of claim 1, wherein the container includes a front and a top edge, and the groin area protector is operatively associated with the top edge and the front of the container to secure the groin area protector to the front of the container configured to protect the groin area of the catcher while catching, and operatively associating the groin area protector includes operatively associating the groin area protector with the top edge and the front of the container configured to protect at least the catcher's groin area during catching.

4. A method of using the catching protection assembly of claim 3, wherein the groin area protector includes a container front receiver configured to slide over and receive the front of the container to secure the groin area protector to the container, and a groin protection member that extends forward and upward from the container front receiver and the front of the container configured to protect the groin area of the catcher while catching, and operatively associating the groin area protector includes receiving the container front receiver over the front of the container to secure the groin area protector to the container.

5. A method of using the catching protection assembly of claim 1, wherein the container includes a reversible and combination lid and seat with one side having a rigid top surface and an opposite side having a cushion member, and transporting with the container includes transporting with the rigid top surface of the reversible and combination lid and seat face up, and receiving on the container includes receiving the catcher seated on the container with the cushion member face up.
